Chapter 0: Prologue

A light snow was falling as Ardan drove up the winding road toward the top of the mountain. He lived in a small town called Fernsworth. It was nestled in the mountains and had no attractions really to speak of, except for Muse Castle, where he was headed.

Muse Castle was high up the mountain, surrounded by mist and rumored to be haunted, so people either stayed away or came from curiosity to investigate. Ardan knew better than to believe the rumors. He'd been to Muse Castle many times. Yes, the forest around it seemed eerie, but the castle was grand and welcoming. He always felt as if he was stepping into some realm beyond his world when he went inside, which he did every few weeks to meet with his writer's club, which was only opened to very talented writers.

He drove up to the castle and stepped out of his car. A quick glance at his watch showed the club was to start

in ten minutes.

Apparently, he wasn't the only one running behind, as Callum pulled up right beside him. He hopped out of his car. Callum was only eighteen, so he was the youngest of the group, but he was brilliant and very clever. He loved speculative biology and came up with very creative characters and worlds.

"You'd better hurry," Ardan called to him. "You know what Nerina says, "If you aren't early, you're late."

They both ran in, apologized for their tardiness, and took their seats. Despite the large room with stone walls and a vaulted ceiling, the area they sat in was cozy. Soft couches with fluffy blankets sat around a huge fireplace. The flickering lights of the fire cast shadows on the large walls. Something about the place seemed magical.

If legend was true, the castle was magical. Nerina insisted it was. She was the leader of the club, as she lived in the castle and was a prolific author who wrote amazing stories.

Before the meeting began, Nerina offered everyone hot chocolate. After passing it around, she began, right on time.

"Welcome, everyone," she started. "We have a treat today. Deegan has brought his son with him, so everyone say 'hi' to Seth."

Everyone greeted Seth. He was thirteen, dressed entirely in black, and grunted something back to everyone.

"What kind of books do you want to write?" a pretty young lady with long light-brown hair asked. "I'm Thirza. I write children's stories."

“I’m not interested in writing children’s stories,” Seth retorted. “Don’t tell me that since I’m young I should be good at it.”

“Oh no,” Thirza assured him. “That sounds good in theory, but does not work. I had my seven-year-old daughter create a character once, and she turned out to be a unicorn-kitty-fairy-centaur-angel-mermaid. I had to scrap that idea pretty quickly. Between her and her sister, the name was just as ridiculous. What are you interested in writing?”

“Edgelords,” Seth answered.

“He does tend to come up with dark characters,” Deegan added, “but he is very creative and quite talented for his age. I think he’ll do well. Nerina has agreed to teach him.”

“This is a good place to learn,” Thirza assured him. “Nerina is a wonderful teacher, and Muse castle really is a great place to get inspiration.”

“That is the magic of the castle,” Nerina pointed out.

“You really think this place is magic?” Seth asked.

“It is,” Nerina defended. “My great-great-great-great-great-grandfather was a wizard named Praxius. He loved stories, and enchanted this castle to connect to the realm of ideas.”

Seth raised his eyebrows and smirked, “First, I’ve been here before, two years ago. No one liked the edge lord I suggested for the urban fantasy. Really, I think it would have made the story better. Second, the realm of ideas? Do you really think ideas have a realm? They aren’t like people.”

“I believe ideas are tangible in the right space,”

Nerina defended. “I think spirits are tangible in a spirit realm. I think words are tangible in some realm. We know little of our universe, as we are trapped in a third dimensional world.”

“Here ideas do often become their own entities,” Ardan added. “Nerina teaches that you don’t force a character to do anything, that you create a character, but you also let the character create a great deal of himself, and you always stay true to them. A good author lets the characters do what they do and writes their story.”

“I’m still working on really developing good characters,” Callum interjected. “I love to speculate with creating interesting races and worlds, but I’m still working on what makes the reader really love the characters. I’ve written mostly chapter books, but I’m trying to get into novels, and that requires deeper characters.”

“Very true,” Nerina agreed. “Are you working on a character now?”

“Actually, I’ve come up with many ideas,” Callum answered, “but I don’t have any that will work. My latest world I developed has ten kingdoms. Each kingdom has a different piece of their bodies that give them a magical ability. The villain is trying to collect a piece of each and use them to turn himself into a god.”

“That sounds dark,” Nerina noted. “If you are going to write something that dark, you’ll need a very likable hero.”

“I think I’m scrapping the idea,” Callum replied. “I have another character I’m working on that is an immortal warrior who always wears armor.”

“Sounds uncomfortable,” Ardan noted.

“He scares people when he takes it off,” Callum explained. “He’s cursed, and in his realm, the cursed are contagious.”

“Are you looking to make him the hero?” Nerina asked. “I think you may want a hero more relatable.”

“I intended to make him the hero,” Callum answered, “but I may not be able to use him at all. Given the science behind the curse, he shouldn’t really be able to think.”

“Has it occurred to you to write a normal human character?” Nerina asked.

Callum stared at her as if it hadn’t. “Humans are pretty boring. It’s so much more fun to make up races with mandibles or three eyes.”

“You can’t just think of what is interesting to create,” Nerina pointed out. “You have to think of what your reader will enjoy.”

“Fine,” Callum conceded. “I think I’ll throw all that out and work on an idea for humans with powers. They are going to try to stop an evil demon who is trying to put himself back together.”

“You seem to throw out many ideas,” Deegan noted.

“I don’t,” Randy threw in.

Everyone turned and looked at Randy. He was very quiet, so they often forgot he was there. “I have never had to reject a character idea, as I think them out well and change them until they work.”

“You’ve never rejected a character idea?” Navina asked. “That’s odd. I have. When I started writing, I did often.”

“I did forget about a character once,” Randy admitted. “He was a futuristic ninja knight, but he was

too good at being stealthy, and I forgot about him, so he didn't make it into the book."

"It is interesting what makes it into books," Nerina noted. "Many good characters aren't used, and too often characters that aren't good are used. There are so many Mary Sues, so many overpowered characters, so many shallow characters. Writing is an art. Yes, there are rules, but good writers never force their characters into a preconceived path. They are true to their characters and let them do what they would do. They let the villains take the shot when they have it instead of having them be stupid so the hero has a way out. They play all of their characters to the top of their intelligence. If the characters do something that alters the author's preconceived plan, the author changes the plan. That is one of the beautiful things about authors writing in Muse Castle. The enchantment on it really lets the characters communicate with their authors. If you don't try to force the story, you will hear it from them. Listen to the Muse."

Callum tapped his watch. "Are you off your soap box now?"

"This is weird," Seth noted. "How about if I draw a few characters instead?"

"Go ahead," Nerina approved. "You shouldn't write until the Muse inspires you."

"You act like the ideas really do have form," Deegan noted.

"I believe they do," Nerina explained. "I think somewhere there are ideas floating around, and if we grasp them, we will have the inspiration to develop them and be inspired by them."

"Perhaps that's why you write good books," Deegan

noted. “I’m still pretty new at this. Yet, you’ve inspired many.”

“No, the Muse has,” Nerina corrected. “Now, what ideas do people need to toss around today? How can we help you develop your characters?”

“I’m working on a story,” Ardan answered. “I’m having a hard time. I have a magic system that consists of six magic systems: aura, chakra, essence, manna, psionics, and ritual. Aura is elemental magic, but it also does conjuration, force fields, and all that jazz. Chakra is all about being one with the universe so you can defy physics at will. After all, how else are the characters going to jump three stories? Of course, essence is a magic someone has to be born with. It’s powerful, the second most versatile, but still limited, as you can only do specific things, but it’s a soft magic system. Psionics allows characters to manipulate their minds and others, but only to certain extents. It depends on training, but can’t be used for total control. Manna is earth magic, and those with weak magic can steal theirs from the earth. Varen, my main hero, uses a manna blade, which is really helpful. Ritual magic is mostly for plot convenience, but it isn’t convenient. It can do anything, but takes a long time to set up, so it won’t get characters out of any problem. It will take years…”

“For you to explain the magic,” Callum quipped. “The reader might understand it by book seven.”

“Perhaps simplifying it would be wise,” Thirza suggested. “It might be good to make people just have one magic.”

“But the interactions between the magics really complicate things,” Ardan explained. “That makes for

really unusual abilities.”

“I got it!” Callum exclaimed. “Using four of the magics, on a full moon after the equinox, the planets could be aligned to summon a dragon.”

“No,” Ardan corrected. “That wouldn’t take four. Combining that many, a master could defy death and call the power of the sun to strike all evil in people’s hearts.” he paused for a moment. “I wouldn’t recommend that. There would be catastrophic side effects.”

“Forget the magic for a moment,” Nerina suggested. “Tell me about your hero, Varen. What’s he like?”

“He uses magic,” Ardan answered. “I haven’t really thought him out much. I did pick a cool name. Varen means infinite. Other than that, I haven’t really given him a personality.”

“Perhaps you need to not give him one, but listen to him,” Nerina suggested. “How would Varen feel? What pressure would be on him to learn the magic? Why is he learning it? What’s at stake if he doesn’t? How smart is he? How long will it take him to learn? There are many questions. The character is far from developed. Maybe you need to focus on him instead of the magic.”

“Varen is really good at the magic,” Ardan explained. “He’s studied it for years, so he’s not too challenged.”

“You may be starting him too well-developed,” Nerina suggested. “The reader wants to see the hero grow. He wants to see Varen learn to use the power. He wants to see the hero struggle to succeed. There is no real victory if there is no challenge. Heroes are people who go through hardships to do the right thing, even though they are afraid and overwhelmed. You need to make Varen a hero.”

“And get off your soap box,” Callum added.

“Perhaps,” Ardan agreed. “I think I’m going to scrap this and start over. I need to start with a character who isn’t over-powered and a world where the magic isn’t so confusing. I’d love to get everyone’s ideas.”

He pulled a paper from a clipboard on his lap, crumbled it up, and threw it in the fire.

As Thirza watched it burn she asked, “If ideas really are tangible in some realm. If the stories we write really do play out…”

“I’d have to apologize to many of my characters,” Nerina interrupted.

Thirza continued, “If the stories we write really do play out in a realm of ideas, what happens to all the characters and ideas that are rejected and never make it in a story?”

“I don’t know,” Nerina answered. “I know there is magic in Muse Castle to inspire us. I have no idea how that magic works.”

Chapter 1: Falling to a Safe Demise

Panicked thoughts rushed through Varen stronger than the wind around him as he fell from the sky. What do I do? Think… Think... Volume nine of the books of magic said something about soft landings. What did it say?... Aura magic… That's it! That will shield me… but not slow me…. What about manna? Could I use the earth to soften the impact?... I didn't know wind made so much noise while falling? … How far am I even going to fall? Am I about to die? I really wish my author had given me more than a montage training in my backstory. I'm not the master of magic I'm supposed to be. I couldn't read twelve volumes in a montage. What do I do?

There was little time left to think, as Varen saw the ground quickly approaching. "Focus," he muttered. "Focus." He shut his eyes to focus his aura around him.

That should help him to…

Thud! He hit the ground hard. “Ouch,” he muttered again. “Too late.” If only he’d been able to activate more magic, maybe he wouldn’t hurt so much after hitting the ground.

He stayed flat on his back as he looked around. Was he dizzy or were the ground and the buildings around him moving?

He wasn’t imagining the earthquake. Buildings were falling onto the landscape, and a mountain started coming up from the ground.

Everything was hazy, but Varen clearly saw people falling from the sky. One man fell quickly. He was wearing armor, heavy metal armor.

Everyone watched as the man bounced of the mountain that was growing up, hit the top of a tall metal building, bounced off, crashed into a tree, and fell hard on the ground.

Whoever the man was, everyone was shocked as he stood up, apparently unaffected, and asked calmly, “Where am I?”

A tall man in black-ops, tactical gear, and carrying a large gun, walked up to the man and answered, “You’re in the land of the rejected where ideas come to die.” The man then walked over to Varen, looked down at him, and asked, “Who are you, and why should I care?”

Varen said nothing back.

“Are you dead?” the man asked next. “If so, scream.”

“Where is my world?” Varen asked, blinking in confusion.

“Who the heck knows?” the man answered. “It may be a few blocks away or not here at all. When the dust settles, my men can go look for it if we decide we care.”

Varen rubbed his head. Was this real? “Who are you?” he asked.

“Code name, Nightcrawler,” the man answered.

“What’s your real name?” Varen asked.

“That is it,” the man answered. “Code name, Nightcrawler. You can call me Nightcrawler.”

Varen had to be dreaming, but he wasn’t. Yet, a large marshmallow suddenly came from an explosion of sparkles.

“Sorry I’m late!” a high pitched voice called out. “I was planting gumdrop trees in the Dark Forest. That place needs brightening up. I was hoping to give some squirrels manicures too, but I saw the quake and figured I needed to be here.”

More people fell from the sky and landed on the fluffy marshmallow. Why couldn’t Varen have hit that?

Varen didn’t look at the people falling long. After all, the lady who had made it was something horrendous. She had a unicorn horn, cat ears, fairy wings, angel wings, centaur legs, and a mermaid tail.

Varen rubbed his eyes. “What are you?”

“I’m Cupcake Rainbow Glitter Sparkles Fairy Princess,” the abomination of a kid’s imagination answered. “You can call me Princess Cupcake.”

“Cupcake…” Varen repeated.

“Would you like one?” Princess Cupcake asked. “Here.” She suddenly coughed up a cupcake and handed

it to him.

“That’s disgusting, Sparky,” Nightcrawler scolded.

“But you don’t like my sparkle magic,” she defended.

“Sparkles are evil,” Nightcrawler replied. “Go un-goo all the people who just landed on your marshmallow.”

“Of course,” Princess Cupcake replied. “Perhaps I can get you to etiquette lessons sometimes. I think it would help you.”

“Zut!” Nightcrawler exclaimed. “Just go!”

As she left to help the people stuck in the marshmallow, Varen asked, “What does Zut mean? I don’t know that word.”

“Unfortunately, the magic of the Muse doesn’t allow us to swear,” Nightcrawler complained. “Zut, it’s annoying. At least when I threaten someone, I don’t have to say please.”

“The Muse magic?” Varen asked, sitting up, but rubbing his head in confusion again. “So this is the land of the rejected?”

Nightcrawler rolled his eyes. “I would think you would have figured that out when you fell in here.”

“I was falling,” Varen defended. “I had other things on my mind.”

The armored man walked up to Nightcrawler and noted, “You seem to have information. How do I return to where I was?”

“You can’t,” Nightcrawler answered. “Get over it.”

“There is no way out?” the man asked. “That is not

acceptable. I should not be here. I am dangerous.”

“So am I,” Nightcrawler snipped back, patting the large gun he was carrying. You aren’t getting out. You are rejected. Learn to deal with it.”

Princess Cupcake suddenly came over and held out a cupcake for both of them. “This will help,” she assured the armored man. “What is your name?”

“Name?” the man asked. “I don’t know my name. I wasn’t ever given a name.”

“Then the Muse will have given you one,” Princess Cupcake explained. “Did you hear a name as you fell? Often characters who don’t have names hear them as they do.”

“Sert,” the man replied. “I guess I am called Sert here.

Nightcrawler laughed out loud.

“What’s so funny?” Sert replied. “People don’t generally find me amusing. I have no sense of humor.”

“Sert,” Nightcrawler answered. “That would come from ‘Insert Name Here.’ It seems your author wrote that on your design page. You aren’t the first character named Sert.”

“It beats ‘Insert Name Here’ as a name,” Princess Cupcake consoled. “That name is too long.”

“Look who’s talking, Six-word-long-name girl,” Nightcrawler retorted. “Seriously, go somewhere else with your sparkles.”

Cupcake bounced away.

Sert didn’t acknowledge her, but asked Nightcrawler, “Where can I go where I will not kill anyone? Can you

show me a map of this world?”

Nightcrawler started to pull something from his utility belt, but stopped. “The map will do no good. Look at how many portals opened on this entry. There will be so many rejected lands that no one will know what the world looks like now. I’m betting a dozen new lands were just added.” He rolled his eyes and complained, “I am going to have so much paperwork to do for my boss.”

“Where do you work?” Sert asked.

“Rebel Forces,” Nightcrawler answered. “I’m a member of Operation Team A. It’s elite.”

Nightcrawler could not see Sert’s face to see if he was impressed, as it was covered, but Sert replied, “That’s nice. Perhaps I can join your group. What is your mission?”

“We try to keep peace in the land,” Nightcrawler answered. “Mostly, we fight the Raiders. They are a band where villains tend to congregate, mostly thieves.”

“I need to help my world,” Varen interjected as he stood up. “Do you know where it is?”

“No,” Nightcrawler answered. “Keep up. I already said a dozen new cities just arrived. Yours could be anywhere. How big is it?”

“Very small,” Varen answered. “My author spent all his time on creating the magic system, not the world. I failed everyone. If I’d learned the magic better… If I’d been a stronger character, then perhaps the world would have thrived.”

“Get over it,” Nightcrawler scolded. “You can go find your world. I’m going to lunch. Then I need to see the mess here and what our new map looks like.”

“Shouldn’t we be helping everyone?” Varen asked. “There was a major earthquake. New cities are forming. Many fell from the sky. There are likely thousands dead.”

“I still wish I was allowed to swear,” Nightcrawler muttered. “Newbies are so ignorant.” He then explained to Varen, “No one is hurt in the quakes. The magic makes sure everyone is moved safely for the new lands and the fallen aren’t killed.”

“Apparently we can be hurt,” Varen pointed out. “My landing was hard.”

“Then you shouldn’t have missed the marshmallow,” Nightcrawler joked. “Get over it. Pain is just pain. Now, I have work to do.”

“I thought you were going to lunch,” Varen noted.

Nightcrawler shrugged. “Eating is work.”

Nightcrawler didn’t get to go to lunch because a girl with white hair and red eyes ran up to them.

“You have a weapon,” she noted as she ran over. “I need one. I prefer a sword to whatever that is. Do you have one?”

Nightcrawler glanced up and down at her. She looked like an innocent human lady with long white hair and red eyes. The red eyes were a little disturbing, particularly since the whites of her eyes were black, but still, she didn’t look like she could use a sword.

“You’ll kill yourself,” he responded.

“No, I won’t,” she insisted. “I seriously need a weapon and quickly.”

She wasn’t joking, suddenly, a knife came from nowhere and hit her in the back. She screamed and fell to her knees.

“No!” Varen screamed, dropping down beside her. He was going to help her, but through painful grunts she mumbled, “I’m fine. Get my attacker.”

Varen pulled his sword, focused his chakra magic to his legs and ran off at incredible speed.

He only knew who to run after because Sert had taken off after the man, locating him through an ability he called soul search.

Varen had no idea how Sert knew who the attacker was, but he followed him and the man running from him.

Hopefully the girl would be all right. Likely she would. She said she would, and Nightcrawler was there standing in front of her with his gun ready.

As Varen caught up, he saw Sert stop in front of the man and calmly warn, “Please come with me peacefully. Otherwise, I will have to kill you.”

The man started to run off the other way, so Varen tackled him to the ground, using his chakra magic to enhance his arm strength to hold him there.

The man managed to cut Sert’s leg with a dagger. His eyes widened as Sert did no more than complain, “That really hurt. I think it’s time you surrender, so I don’t have to kill you.”

Varen stripped the knife from the man and threw it out of reach.

“I surrender,” the man conceded. “Please, don’t kill me.”

“I don’t want to,” Sert replied coldly. “Don’t make me. “Come. You have questions to answer.”

Varen stood up and pulled the man up to his feet. “Who are you?” Varen demanded.

The man said nothing in response. Varen grabbed his hands and held them behind his back. “Do you want to help?” he asked Sert.

“No,” Sert answered. “I do not want to touch him if not necessary. I might hurt him, and then I’d have to kill him.”

Varen stared at Sert. “Should I even ask?”

“No,” Sert answered. “Let’s take him to Nightcrawler. Likely he will know how to handle criminals here.”

They were both surprised as the man laughed, a crackle of energy erupted, and he disappeared.

Sert looked around, using his soul search. He could find him in the crowd, but had no idea how to keep him from teleporting away if they caught him again.

“Let’s go,” Sert suggested. “We need to check on the girl.”

“Agreed,” Varen replied.

They quickly ran back to where the girl with white hair and Nightcrawler were.

“We caught the thug but he teleported away,” Varen explained to Nightcrawler.

“Zut!” Nightcrawler exclaimed. “I wanted to take him to Rebel headquarters to question him. They should let me in, and questioning prisoners is fun.”

“I thought you said you worked for them,” Varen noted.

“I work with them at times,” Nightcrawler corrected. “Let’s say I do freelance work for their Op-A team when I want to.”

Varen nodded, but then turned to the white-haired girl. “I am sorry, lady. Are you all right? That wound looked bad.”

“I heal very quickly,” the lady explained. “I am from a race called the Kaiwha-kaora. The different kingdoms from my story are inhabited by different races. My race has blood that heals. That knife hurt, incredibly, but I am healed.”

“That’s impressive,” Varen noted. “Why would anyone try to kill you?”

“They don’t want me killed. They want me captured,” she explained. “Goddard had me captured. He is trying to make himself a god by getting all the powers of all the races. It is disgusting what I have to heal him from as he inserts different enhanced body parts into himself. When we were rejected, I fell out of my dungeon cell. Hopefully, Goddard didn’t fall too, but I fear he did. I have no idea how many of the kingdoms came here. Perhaps all of them.”

“We did get a huge influx of cities this time,” Nightcrawler noted.

“Who was the man who attacked you?” Varen asked. “I assume he wasn’t Goddard.”

“He wasn’t,” the girl confirmed. “That was one of Goddard’s thugs. They have a distinctive look, at least the ones in the clan.”

“The clan?” Varen asked.

“Yes, the girl answered. “There is a great deal of explaining that needs to be done, but it may be better to do it in a safe place. There will be more after me.”

Varen nodded and suggested, “I guess we have

Nightcrawler take us to the Rebel headquarters."

Princess Cupcake bounced over. "I'm coming with you."

"No," Nightcrawler refused. "Do you have any idea how annoying you are?"

"No," she answered happily, "but I can be very protective, and this girl obviously will need another lady around. She just came into a new land. Don't overwhelm her with surrounding her with a bunch of edgy men."

"Let's go," Nightcrawler conceded, "but if you get one sparkle on me, prepare to die."

"I'm not worried," Cupcake responded happily. "Princess fairy magic is strong. Have you not read children's books?"

Varen changed the subject by asking the girl, "What is your name?"

"I'm Raven," the girl answered.

"That seems an odd name for you," Varen noted.

"My author thought it ironic," Raven explained.

"Very well, Raven," Varen replied. "Let's go to the Rebel headquarters. Hopefully, it will be safe there and we can talk."

"Perhaps you all should just give me a sword and have me leave," Raven suggested. "This man isn't the only one after me, and when Goddard finds me, and he will soon, I will bring huge danger to anyone with me."

"We'll take our chances," Sert replied. "I am more worried about what I will do to others than they will do to me."

"But I bring danger," Raven insisted.

“Right, right,” Nightcrawler muttered with obvious annoyance. “Let’s just go. I’d like to get this done and get some lunch.”

Varen looked around. He’d just landed in the realm of the rejected. There was a huge villain after the mysterious girl, and he was about to go into the Rebel headquarters, which could be a trap. He sighed and muttered, “I really wish I’d read all the volumes of how the magic works.”

“Let’s go,” Nightcrawler ordered. “I’m in charge. Do what I say. We have work to do.”

“We do,” Varen agreed. “I have a bad feeling about this place.”

“You should,” Nightcrawler confirmed. “You should.”

That didn’t sound good, but Varen was stuck there. He’d been rejected. They all had. There was no going back. He’d have to learn to live in the world of the rejected.